



Gameboy Apple Watch

iOS developer gets old-school Gameboy emulator running on Apple Watch. <http://dgit.in/iOSGameboy>



McLaren's new 720S

Want to feel like a professional driver? Well, you can with McLaren's 720S, but only if you're rich enough. <http://dgit.in/McL720S>

IEMs

Features & Performance: The S3 feels fairly mellow when you compare it to the sharp, hard hitting sound signature of say the RHA S500i. This was immediately noticed on our crunchy metal track, *Selkies* by *Between The Buried And Me*. While the S3 is broad and expansive, the other similarly priced Brainwavz device in the test, the B100, is tighter with its bass and slightly more accurate. When playing *Stereo Love* by Edward Maya feat. Vika Jigulina we noticed that the whooshes and echos sound more pleasing on the S3 as compared to the more upfront presentation of the B100. The passive isolation in

Verdict: The Brainwavz S3 is a solid performer in terms of tonal accuracy and presentation. Sure, you won't get the analytical type sound signature of true monitors but the question is are you really looking for that? With the S3 you get a pair of nice sounding trendy looking in-ears that can easily be your daily driver.

PROS

- + Fairly detailed sound
- + Feels solid and durable
- + Cable relatively tangle free
- + Looks nice

CONS

- Remote buttons hard to press
- Bass could've been more accurate

FiiO EX1 (2ND GEN)

If the Brainwavz S3 felt premium, the FiiO EX1 just took it a notch further. The box is well designed and the headphones themselves feel solid to hold. FiiO, at least for us, has always been that company which makes high quality portable headphone amps. The EX1 was our first experience with a headphone from FiiO. And quite a pleasant experience it was.

Build & Design: The FiiO EX1 goes to great lengths to tell you that it's made from the very best materials. It's apparently got nanotech titanium diaphragms which are supposed to be nanometer-thin. The housing is crafted from aircraft-grade duralumin which makes the earpieces fairly lightweight. FiiO has even slapped on a "Hi-Res Audio" logo on the box, which even today feels funny to us when it accompanies analog devices. We have to admit the headphones look

stylish, and feel comfortable even over extended periods. However there are a few flaws. The volume control pod for instance has too much play and feels like it might be the first thing to give way. The carrying case although rock solid, is too slim. You really need to carefully wind the cable in order to make sure it doesn't get caught in the lids while closing the case.

Performance: Performance-wise the EX1 is not bad at all, and very much in the region of the S3. The detail and bass response was quite nice on *Mindstreet* by *Motherjane*. The bass was tight, the cymbal tapping at the beginning fairly detailed, and the gritty nature of the electric guitar was maintained. Quite impressive honestly. Overall the lows and lower-mids seem enhanced. They falter slightly when it came to live performances. The illusion of space was lacking and vocals seemed less rich but more upfront – not unpleasant; just different.

Though not quite the "bass king" of this shootout, it definitely packs a decent punch. The microphone on the EX1 was hands down the best in the test.

Verdict: For the price the FiiO EX1 (2nd Gen) is not a bad purchase at all. It reproduces most genres fairly well and does better with guitar / bass driven rock. They are a little more livelier than the Brainwavz S3 with fairly decent bass.

PROS

- + Does well on tracks with string bass
- + Good build quality on driver housing and cable
- + Tangle free
- + Stylish design

CONS

- Carrying case feels a little too small
- The volume rocker feels flimsy

BRAINWAVZ B100

Build and design: The Brainwavz B100 is perhaps the most inexpensive balanced armature IEM in the market today. It's got a purely functional design – basic Y cable and plugs that have a memory cable at the end which functions as additional support by going around the ear. In fact, the headphones are downright plain looking to be honest. While the B100 is certainly not going to win any design awards, what it lacks in looks, it makes up in audio chops.

Features & performance: From our test tracks, it became pretty apparent that the B100 was likely to be the most precise IEM in the test. Chris Rea's vocals on *Call on Me* felt more natural than any of the other headphones. Even the live track – *Shine On* – sounded quite nice. The only track where the headphone faltered a bit was *Mindstreet* from the *Maktub* album. The twangy bass didn't have that oomph. Ahh well, you can't have it all.

Verdict: The Brainwavz B100 is an incredibly accurate in-ear for its price. For a budding audiophile wanting to try out balanced armature type IEMs (as opposed to regular old dynamics) the B100 could be the perfect starting point. The sound signature was fairly neutral and handled most of genres we threw at it. It seems to be positioned as a "serious" headphone and even drops the in-line microphone all together. At 50 Ohms the rated impedance is on the

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Brainwavz S3

the S3 is excellent. The finesse in reproduction and level of detail is surprisingly good for a regular consumer focused IEM. Overall the sound signature was decidedly mid-boosted but not in a bad way. While listening to *Shine On You Crazy Diamond* from the Pulse Live concert, I found the ambience to be present but certain details went missing for instance the sharp edge on Wright's Organ was very subdued. In terms of microphone capture quality, it fell behind the Cowon EX1.